ALLY WEALTH • AUTHOR VISIBILITY CONSULTANT

ARC & Reader Outreach Guide

A respectful framework for advance reader copies, reader discovery and voluntary feedback.

A practical workbook and reference guide

EDUCATIONAL RESOURCE • 2026 EDITION

How to use this guide

Advance reader copy (ARC) outreach can help a book reach interested readers before or around publication. It is relationship work, not a mechanism for purchasing praise. Readers choose whether to participate, whether to finish and whether to review. This guide focuses on fit, clarity, consent and ethical follow-through.

Work through the pages in order. Use the prompts to make decisions, record assumptions and identify actions. You can revisit a page when your book, audience or publishing plan changes.

Keep the work evidence-aware. Platform interfaces, policies and marketplace features change. Verify current official guidance before acting on platform-specific instructions. Treat examples as planning aids, not guarantees.

Make it your own. Not every tactic belongs in every campaign. Choose the actions that fit your book, resources, readers and values.

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Understand the purpose of an ARC

An ARC is an advance copy shared for early reading or feedback. Define whether your purpose is editorial feedback, early awareness, or inviting voluntary reviews. Do not treat all three as interchangeable.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **understand the purpose of an arc**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

• What is the smallest useful next step, who owns it, and when will it be reviewed?

Working notes

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Set realistic expectations

An invitation does not guarantee a download, a completed read, a review or a positive response. Build a plan that remains worthwhile even when participation is lower than expected.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **set realistic expectations**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Confirm the book is ready

Check that the manuscript is sufficiently complete, proofread and formatted for the intended reading experience. Tell recipients if the file is an uncorrected proof and explain what may change.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **confirm the book is ready**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Define the right reader

Describe genre, subject, tone, themes and content considerations. The best recipient is someone likely to be genuinely interested, not simply someone with a large following.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **define the right reader**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Research reader fit

Review public reading interests and recent activity where appropriate. Use only information that is relevant and publicly available; do not infer private traits or collect unnecessary personal data.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **research reader fit**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Build a small, relevant list

Track names or public handles, source, genre fit, contact date and response status. Keep the list proportionate and secure. Avoid scraping or buying personal contact databases.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **build a small, relevant list**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
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Working notes

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Respect community rules

Read group, forum and platform rules before sharing an invitation. Some spaces prohibit promotion or ARC requests. Ask moderators where rules are unclear.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **respect community rules**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Write a personal invitation

Mention why the book may fit the recipient’s interests. State the format, approximate timing, content notes and what participation involves. Make it easy to decline.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **write a personal invitation**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Explain review independence

Make clear that any review is voluntary and that honest opinions are welcome. Never request a positive rating, prescribe wording or make benefits conditional on favourable sentiment.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **explain review independence**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Understand disclosure duties

If a recipient receives a free copy or other benefit, they may need to disclose it under applicable law or platform policy. Encourage recipients to check the rules relevant to them.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **understand disclosure duties**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Choose a delivery method

Select a file or service that is secure, accessible and appropriate for the reader. Confirm device compatibility and avoid collecting more personal information than needed.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **choose a delivery method**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Protect the manuscript

Use sensible file naming and distribution practices. If the work is confidential, state that clearly, but do not imply that ordinary technical measures can prevent all copying.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **protect the manuscript**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Prepare a reader information sheet

Include title, author, genre, release timing, format, content notes, reading order and a neutral explanation of optional feedback or review routes.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare a reader information sheet**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Plan the outreach timeline

Allow time for invitations, responses, reading and voluntary reviews. Build in flexibility for readers' schedules and do not pressure recipients to meet arbitrary deadlines.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **plan the outreach timeline**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Send one clear follow-up

If appropriate, send a polite follow-up after a reasonable interval. Do not repeatedly message people who have not responded or who have declined.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **send one clear follow-up**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Track responses respectfully

Record only necessary operational details: invited, accepted, file sent, declined or no response. Avoid labelling readers by the sentiment of their feedback.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **track responses respectfully**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Handle feedback privately

Thank readers for their time. If they provide private editorial feedback, do not publish it as a testimonial without explicit permission. Separate private comments from public reviews.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **handle feedback privately**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Respond to negative feedback

Do not argue with readers or ask them to change honest opinions. Use feedback to understand expectations, clarity or potential manuscript issues while respecting the reader's perspective.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **respond to negative feedback**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Avoid review manipulation

Do not buy reviews, exchange reviews in prohibited ways, create fake accounts or coordinate ratings. Do not ask friends or family with a close relationship to misrepresent independence.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **avoid review manipulation**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Work with bloggers and reviewers

Check each reviewer’s submission rules, preferred genres, lead times and disclosure practices. Personalise the pitch and accept that a reviewer may decline or not respond.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **work with bloggers and reviewers**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Support inclusive outreach

Consider readers with different access needs and formats. Provide accessible files where possible and describe content clearly so readers can make informed choices.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **support inclusive outreach**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Manage consent and data

Explain why you are contacting someone, keep data secure and honour deletion or opt-out requests. Follow relevant privacy and anti-spam laws.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **manage consent and data**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Use reader communities ethically

Participate as a member, not only as a promoter. Share useful discussion and follow community norms. Avoid repeated unsolicited messages or misleading engagement.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **use reader communities ethically**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Prepare a launch handoff

If a reader chooses to post a review, provide the correct public book link and release information. Do not monitor or pressure them to publish.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **prepare a launch handoff**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Close the ARC cycle

Send a final thank-you, close the invitation window and remove unnecessary personal data. Keep only records needed for legitimate business purposes.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **close the arc cycle**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Evaluate the outreach process

Review recipient fit, clarity of invitation, response patterns and operational workload. Do not judge success solely by review count or rating.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **evaluate the outreach process**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Build long-term reader relationships

Invite ongoing connection only where appropriate and with consent. A one-time ARC recipient is not automatically a permanent marketing contact.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **build long-term reader relationships**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Create an outreach message bank

Prepare adaptable invitation, acceptance, delivery, reminder and thank-you templates. Personalise every message and verify details before sending.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **create an outreach message bank**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

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Working notes

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Troubleshoot common scenarios

Plan for file problems, schedule changes, recipient withdrawal, delayed publication and requests outside your scope. Respond clearly and without blame.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **troubleshoot common scenarios**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

- Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?
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Working notes

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Your ethical ARC checklist

Confirm readiness, fit, consent, disclosure, independence, privacy, file quality and follow-up. If any element is unclear, pause and resolve it before outreach.

Put this into practice

Write down the current situation for **your ethical arc checklist**. What is already working? What is unclear? What evidence do you have, and what are you assuming? Identify one change that would make the experience clearer or more useful for the intended reader.

Decision questions

• Who is this action intended to help, and what would that person need to understand?

• What facts, permissions or platform rules must be checked before proceeding?

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Working notes